

Monsoon & Climatology

Monsoon mechanism, jet streams, ENSO links and climate classification - physical geography staple.

Portion focus ~78% · Topic: geo-physical

PYQ themes: Monsoon onset · Jet streams · ENSO · Climate classification · Rainfall patterns

Why this portion (PYQ lens)

Portion chance ~78%. Steady across decade; parent geo-physical ~79%.

Years appeared (synthesis): 2016, 2017, 2018, 2019, 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023, 2024, 2025

Why UPSC asks this

Mechanism statements and ENSO/monsoon links are classic Prelims geography.

Syllabus framing

Portion chance ~78%. Steady across decade; parent geo-physical ~79%. This portion sits inside geo-physical and centres on Indian monsoon and climatology. Mechanism statements and ENSO/monsoon links are classic Prelims geography.

Recurring PYQ angles: Monsoon onset, Jet streams, ENSO, Climate classification, Rainfall patterns. Approximate appearance years in the 2016-2025 educational synthesis: 2016, 2017, 2018, 2019, 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023, 2024, 2025. Use the chance percentage only to sequence study hours - it is not an official prediction.

Core map of Indian monsoon and climatology

Differential heating: Land - sea thermal contrast sets monsoon stage. ITC shift: Seasonal migration of wind belts influences inflow.

Somali jet / Findlater: Cross-equatorial flow into Arabian Sea branch narrative. Southwest monsoon branches: Arabian Sea and Bay of Bengal branches.

Hold this core map as your elimination spine before memorising peripheral CA overlays.

Core concepts and definitions

Orography: Western Ghats and Himalaya shape rainfall distribution. Break and active periods: Intra-seasonal monsoon variability.

Northeast monsoon: Tamil Nadu rainfall season contrast. ENSO: El Niño often linked to weaker monsoon - probabilistic not absolute.

Institutions, processes and mechanisms

IOD: Indian Ocean Dipole modulates monsoon independently at times. Western Disturbances: Winter/spring precip in northwest India.

Jet streams: Subtropical jet / easterly jet roles in onset narratives. Climate classification: Koeppen-type codes for India - revise map.

India angle and applied examples

Climate change overlay: Monsoon statistics shifting - careful wording. Monsoon trough: Location influences rainfall belts.

Bay lows/depressions: Rain producers in peak season. Retreating monsoon: September - December transitions.

Comparisons, linkages and discriminators

Rain-shadow: Leeward dryness - Ghats example. Mango showers / blossom showers: Local pre-monsoon terms.

Onset criteria: IMD operational definitions - conceptual. Flood vs drought years: Teleconnections + local factors.

India angle

IMD onset/progress maps are CA; mechanism remains static spine.

Question patterns and exam spine

Matching lists and statements on Indian monsoon and climatology.

Revision spine: Definitions -> table -> India -> traps.

Eliminate anachronisms and category errors first, then test remaining options against table rows and must-remember triggers.

Trap watch-list (specific)

Avoid: El Niño always means full monsoon failure. Avoid: Ignoring orography. Avoid: Mixing NE and SW monsoon regions. Avoid: Absolute jet-stream claims.

Monsoon quick map

Idea | Hook

SW monsoon -- June - Sep main

NE monsoon -- TN focus

ENSO -- Probabilistic link

Orography -- Ghats/Himalaya

Map / list facts

- Western Ghats rain-shadow
- Bay of Bengal branch path
- TN NE monsoon

Common traps

- x El Niño always means full monsoon failure
- x Ignoring orography
- x Mixing NE and SW monsoon regions
- x Absolute jet-stream claims

Must remember

- Two SW branches
- Orography role
- ENSO probabilistic
- NE monsoon TN
- Jet/onset narrative
- Koeppen India map

Quick revision checklist

- ☐ Reproduce table
- ☐ 5 must-remembers
- ☐ 3 traps
- ☐ India anchor
- ☐ 10 MCQs

Educational prioritisation heuristic - not an official UPSC prediction. (c) UPSC IAS Study Hub original notes.